

Is it true that training AI costs far more energy than using it and that using it doesn't actually add to the energy consumption and carbon dioxide emissions?

Posted by u/Yo_Mama_The_Llama • 0 points • 3 comments

I have a really hard time wrapping my head around stuff like AI but my impression is that it's a huge issue for the environment and I for that reason avoid taking any active part in using it. However I have a much more tech savvy boyfriend who is much more positive about the progress of AI who claims I won't be adding to the burning of fossil fuels etc by using an already trained and existing AI Model because it's the training that is the problem. My gut is telling me he's oversimplifying this and because I'm fucking stupid I don't have any good counter arguments.

I would really appreciate a dumbed down explanation of the energy consumption of the different aspects of AI and specifically if I do add to it or not by for example using let's say ChatGPT.

Comments

u/bangbangracer • 2 points • 2025-04-21 13:13 UTC

Lets just start by saying that everything AI does is massive when it comes to energy consumption. From training, to the actual use, to building new data centers for it, it all is a huge consumer of energy and water.

This isn't really as clear cut as you might think. It's a bit like comparing the fuel usage of a city bus to a car. Yes, the bus produces more exhaust and consumes more fuel than a commuter car, but per passenger, it's doing far less. The initial training of the AI will consume more energy, but that training doesn't just disappear after each use.

u/Yo_Mama_The_Llama • 1 points • 2025-04-21 13:29 UTC

Thanks for your explanation.

I guess my gut is telling me I'd just rather not be part of it no matter how small an impact I would have using it. I could perhaps compare it to buying shit from Temu, the damage I as a single person do ordering one item in a eternal stream of dogshit is barely measurable, but that tiny bit still is a microscopic part of the bigger problem I can't get behind and while I realize me choosing

to not buy a product or use a service won't make a difference it gives me more peace of mind for me personally to not partake in what I deem destructive or the very least counter productive. I just feel like he considers my knowledge and understanding of the subject so subpar that he just sees my scepticism as stubbornness, immaturity and perhaps pride and I really dislike feeling stupid.

Do you know of any good source of data on the continuous energy consumption of for example ChatGPT?

u/AkaiShuuichi9866 • 1 points • 2025-04-21 12:40 UTC

There's two parts to an AI: Training and Inference.

Training a large model like ChatGPT is obviously going to be a lengthy and energy consuming task. In comparison, a single inference is going to consume much less energy.

But ChatGPT is used by millions of people worldwide. The inference is pretty much constantly happening as opposed to the training which is a onetime thing (per model).

Still, the energy consumption from you as an individual asking it a couple of questions now and then is negligible compared to the overall energy consumption from all the other users.